

Radiative transitions of B_{c1} states in hard-photon QCD sum rules

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Abstract

We study the radiative transitions $B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$, $B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$, $B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$, and $B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$ in a heavy-heavy three-point QCD sum-rule framework. Since both valence quarks are heavy, the leading radiative contribution is hard photon emission from the charm and anti-bottom lines rather than a photon-distribution-amplitude term. Using physical-current residues from the two-point B_c -mixing sum rules, we find

$$\Gamma[B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c \gamma] = 0.532_{-0.146}^{+0.202} \text{ keV}, \quad \Gamma[B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c \gamma] = 10.04_{-1.75}^{+2.41} \text{ keV}.$$

For the vector final state, using the standard vector-current normalization $f_{B_c^*} = 0.435_{-0.035}^{+0.032} \text{ GeV}$, the baseline current convention gives

$$\Gamma[B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma] = 70.3_{-8.4}^{+10.9} \text{ keV}, \quad \Gamma[B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma] = 382_{-50}^{+55} \text{ keV}.$$

These values include the explicitly integrated all-positive dimension-four gluon-condensate sector. The contact/derivative rows have no ordinary two-channel double-pole support in the physical double-Borel projection. A separate sign and state-assignment audit shows that the vector hierarchy is opposite to representative model calculations, so the $B_c^* \gamma$ entries should be regarded as convention-dependent until an independent tensor-current trace check is completed.

I. INTRODUCTION

The spectroscopy of the B_c family is a particularly clean laboratory for heavy-heavy dynamics. Unlike ordinary heavy-light mesons, the B_c mesons contain two different heavy flavors, and their electromagnetic transitions are sensitive to the relative photon couplings of the charm and anti-bottom quark. Radiative transitions of orbitally excited B_c states therefore provide a useful complement to mass spectroscopy and hadronic transitions.

The observation of structures in the $B_c^+ \gamma$ spectrum by LHCb [1, 2] motivates a direct QCD sum-rule calculation of the corresponding radiative widths. The experimental analysis observes peaks in the visible $B_c^+ \gamma$ invariant mass, but does not measure the individual partial radiative widths. Theoretical predictions for $B_{c1} \rightarrow B_c^{(*)} \gamma$ have been obtained in several potential model and relativistic quark-model approaches [3–11]. The spread among predictions is sizeable, especially for channels in which the spin components of the axial state interfere.

In the strange heavy systems, light-cone QCD sum rules receive important photon-distribution-amplitude contributions. The B_c case is different: there is no light valence quark, and the leading radiative term is the short-distance photon emission from heavy propagators. In this paper we build a hard-photon three-point QCD sum rule for the transitions $B_{c1} \rightarrow B_c \gamma$ and $B_{c1} \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$. The axial-vector currents and residues are matched to the same physical-current basis used in the B_c -mixing two-point analysis. We also give a detailed audit of the dimension-four gluon-condensate sector, since in a heavy-heavy system it is the first natural nonperturbative correction to the perturbative triangle.

The paper is organized as follows. In Sec. II we introduce the interpolating currents, the physical mixing convention, and the radiative form factors. Section III summarizes the hard-photon sum-rule construction and the condensate audit. Numerical inputs, stability checks, and comparison with experiment and other theory are given in Sec. IV. Section V summarizes the results.

II. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

We use two independent axial-vector basis currents,

$$J_\mu^A = \bar{c} \gamma_\mu \gamma_5 b, \quad (1)$$

$$J_\mu^B = \frac{i}{m_b + m_c} \bar{c} \sigma_{\mu\alpha} P^\alpha \gamma_5 b, \quad (2)$$

where P is the momentum of the initial axial-vector state. The physical currents are written as

$$J_{1\mu} = \sin \theta J_\mu^A + \cos \theta J_\mu^B, \quad (3)$$

$$J_{2\mu} = \cos \theta J_\mu^A - \sin \theta J_\mu^B. \quad (4)$$

The lower state $B_{c1}(6743)$ is coupled to $J_{1\mu}$, while the upper state $B_{c1}(6750)$ is coupled to $J_{2\mu}$. The two-point sum-rule diagonalization gives $\theta \simeq 43.3^\circ$ in the numerical window used below.

The decay constants are defined by

$$\langle 0 | \bar{c} i \gamma_5 b | B_c(p) \rangle = \frac{m_{B_c}^2 f_{B_c}}{m_b + m_c}, \quad (5)$$

$$\langle 0 | \bar{c} \gamma_\rho b | B_c^*(p, \xi) \rangle = m_{B_c^*} f_{B_c^*} \xi_\rho, \quad (6)$$

$$\langle 0 | J_{i\mu} | B_{c1}^{(i)}(P, \eta) \rangle = f_i m_i \eta_\mu, \quad i = 1, 2. \quad (7)$$

For the pseudoscalar final state we parametrize the radiative matrix element as

$$\langle B_c(p)\gamma(q, \varepsilon)|B_{c1}^{(i)}(P, \eta)\rangle = eg_i [(\eta \cdot \varepsilon^*)(p \cdot q) - (\eta \cdot q)(p \cdot \varepsilon^*)]. \quad (8)$$

The corresponding width is

$$\Gamma(1^+ \rightarrow 0^- \gamma) = \frac{\alpha_{\text{em}}}{3} g_i^2 \left(\frac{m_i^2 - m_{B_c}^2}{2m_i} \right)^3. \quad (9)$$

For the vector final state we use the gauge-invariant tensor

$$V_{\mu\nu\rho} = p_\nu \epsilon_{\mu\rho\alpha\beta} p^\alpha q^\beta - (p \cdot q) \epsilon_{\mu\nu\rho\alpha} p^\alpha, \quad (10)$$

and define

$$\langle B_c^*(p, \xi)\gamma(q, \varepsilon)|B_{c1}^{(i)}(P, \eta)\rangle = eg_i^* \eta^\mu \varepsilon^{*\nu} \xi^{*\rho} V_{\mu\nu\rho}. \quad (11)$$

The width is evaluated by an explicit polarization sum.

III. QCD SUM RULES

For the $B_c\gamma$ channel the correlation function is

$$\Pi_{i\mu}(p, q) = i \int d^4x e^{ip \cdot x} \langle \gamma(q, \varepsilon) | T \{ J_{i\mu}(x) \bar{b}(0) i\gamma_5 c(0) \} | 0 \rangle. \quad (12)$$

For the $B_c^*\gamma$ channel the pseudoscalar current is replaced by $\bar{b}\gamma_\rho c$. Since both quarks are heavy, the leading OPE is obtained by attaching the photon perturbatively to either the charm line or the anti-bottom line. In the charm-emission topology the three denominators are

$$D_1 = (k + q)^2 - m_c^2, \quad D_2 = k^2 - m_c^2, \quad D_3 = (k - p)^2 - m_b^2, \quad (13)$$

while in the anti-bottom-emission topology they are

$$D_1 = k^2 - m_c^2, \quad D_2 = (k - p)^2 - m_b^2, \quad D_3 = (k - p + q)^2 - m_b^2. \quad (14)$$

The projected perturbative traces generate invariant amplitudes $\widehat{\Pi}_A$ and $\widehat{\Pi}_B$, which are then rotated into the physical basis,

$$\widehat{\Pi}_1 = \sin \theta \widehat{\Pi}_A + \cos \theta \widehat{\Pi}_B, \quad (15)$$

$$\widehat{\Pi}_2 = \cos \theta \widehat{\Pi}_A - \sin \theta \widehat{\Pi}_B. \quad (16)$$

The resulting form factors have the schematic form

$$g_1 = \frac{\exp[(m_1^2 + m_f^2)/(2M^2)]}{m_1 f_1 \mathcal{N}_f} \left(\sin \theta \hat{\Pi}_A + \cos \theta \hat{\Pi}_B \right), \quad (17)$$

$$g_2 = \frac{\exp[(m_2^2 + m_f^2)/(2M^2)]}{m_2 f_2 \mathcal{N}_f} \left(\cos \theta \hat{\Pi}_A - \sin \theta \hat{\Pi}_B \right), \quad (18)$$

where $\mathcal{N}_f = m_{B_c}^2 f_{B_c} / (m_b + m_c)$ for $B_c \gamma$ and $\mathcal{N}_f = m_{B_c^*} f_{B_c^*}$ for $B_c^* \gamma$. For the vector final state we extract g_V with

$$V_{\mu\nu\rho} = p_\nu \epsilon_{\mu\rho p q} - (p \cdot q) \epsilon_{\mu\nu\rho p}.$$

Since this tensor has mass dimension three, g_V has dimension GeV^{-2} . The polarization sum gives

$$\Gamma(1^+ \rightarrow 1^- \gamma) = \frac{\alpha_{\text{em}}}{3} g_V^2 (2m_f^2 + E_\gamma^2) E_\gamma^3,$$

Equivalently,

$$g_{E1} = \sqrt{2m_f^2 + E_\gamma^2} g_V, \quad \Gamma = \frac{\alpha_{\text{em}}}{3} g_{E1}^2 E_\gamma^3.$$

The dimension-four gluon-condensate workbench uses the background-field heavy propagator expansion. The projected G^2 numerators were reduced in powers of D_1, D_2, D_3 . For the vector channel this gives 1095 reduced terms: 538 with all effective denominator powers positive and 557 contact/derivative-sector terms. For the pseudoscalar channel the corresponding all-positive sector contains 375 terms. We integrate these all-positive terms explicitly in the diagonal double-Borel limit $M_1^2 = M_2^2 = 2M^2$. Refined support audits show that the contact/derivative rows do not contain ordinary two-channel double poles. The vector crossed rows depend on $(p - q)^2 = 2p^2 - P^2$, and the pseudoscalar contact rows are either single-virtuality, no-virtuality, or crossed-combination terms. They are kept as audit candidates rather than added to the physical double-Borel sum.

IV. NUMERICAL ANALYSIS

We use $m_b = 4.18 \text{ GeV}$, $m_c = 1.27 \text{ GeV}$, $m_{B_c} = 6.2749 \text{ GeV}$, and $m_{B_c^*} = 6.3359 \text{ GeV}$. The axial-state masses are $m_1 = 6.743 \text{ GeV}$ and $m_2 = 6.751 \text{ GeV}$. The working Borel and continuum windows are

$$M^2 = 7, 8, 9 \text{ GeV}^2, \quad s_0 = 53, 54, 55 \text{ GeV}^2,$$

TABLE I. Present hard-QCDSR results. The quoted intervals are the 16–84 percentile Monte Carlo intervals after including the explicitly integrated all-positive G^2 sector. The $B_c^*\gamma$ entries are baseline current-convention values and remain under the tensor-current sign audit discussed in the text.

Channel	Coupling	Γ [keV]
$B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$	$g_P = +0.0487[0.0414, 0.0572] \text{ GeV}^{-1}$	$0.532^{+0.202}_{-0.146}$
$B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$	$g_P = -0.206[-0.230, -0.188] \text{ GeV}^{-1}$	$10.04^{+2.41}_{-1.75}$
$B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$	$g_V = -0.0764[-0.0821, -0.0717] \text{ GeV}^{-2}$	$70.3^{+10.9}_{-8.4}$
$B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$	$g_V = +0.173[0.161, 0.185] \text{ GeV}^{-2}$	382^{+55}_{-50}

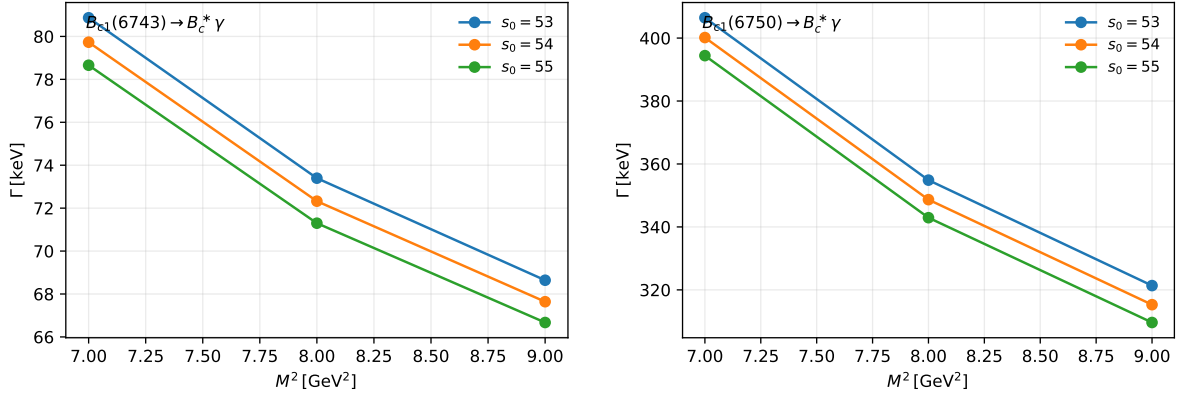


FIG. 1. Representative Borel stability of the vector final-state widths in the standard $f_{B_c^*}$ normalization.

and the vector-current two-point sum rule for $f_{B_c^*}$ uses

$$M_V^2 = 5, 6, 7, 8 \text{ GeV}^2, \quad s_{0,V} = 40, 42, 44 \text{ GeV}^2.$$

The two-point residue grid gives

$$\theta = 43.29^\circ, \quad f_1 = 0.264[0.259, 0.269] \text{ GeV}, \quad f_2 = 0.722[0.709, 0.738] \text{ GeV}.$$

For the vector final-state decay constant we find

$$f_{B_c^*} = 0.435[0.400, 0.467] \text{ GeV}$$

in the standard vector-invariant convention.

TABLE II. Comparison with representative theoretical predictions. Widths are in keV.

Publication	$6743 \rightarrow B_c \gamma$	$6743 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$	$6750 \rightarrow B_c \gamma$	$6750 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$
Godfrey [3]	13	60	80	11
Ebert–Faustov–Galkin [4]	18.4	78.9	132	13.6
Fulcher [5]	32.4	75.6	127.8	26.2
Gershtein et al. [6]	11.6	77.8	131.1	8.1
T. Y. Li et al. [7]	16.6	49	66.6	10.5
Q. Li et al. [8]	35	70	74	40
X. J. Li et al. [9]	30.1	47.8	64	25.6
Eichten–Quigg [10]	9.9	62.5	92.3	7.5
Bondar–Milstein [11]	22	75	47	2
This work	0.532	70.3 [†]	10.04	382 [†]

Table II compares our results with representative model predictions. LHCb has observed the $B_c^+ \gamma$ structure, but the individual partial radiative widths are not measured [1, 2]; hence the comparison is with theory rather than direct width measurements.

[†] Baseline current-convention values; the vector hierarchy is under the tensor-current sign and state-assignment audit.

The small $B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$ width and the comparatively large $B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$ width reflect the strong dependence of the radiative amplitude on the physical-current rotation and on the final-state spin. The vector channels are also sensitive to the normalization of $f_{B_c^*}$; using the reference value $f_{B_c^*} = 0.384 \pm 0.038$ GeV instead of the self-contained standard sum-rule value gives $\Gamma(6743 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma) = 92.6[76.1, 117]$ keV and $\Gamma(6750 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma) = 447[365, 564]$ keV. More importantly, the baseline vector ratio $\Gamma(6750 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma)/\Gamma(6743 \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma) > 1$ is opposite to the representative model pattern. At the central point the lower-state vector combination is cancellation-dominated, $\sin \theta \hat{\Pi}_A + \cos \theta \hat{\Pi}_B \simeq -1.8 \times 10^{-3}$, whereas the higher-state combination is constructive, $\cos \theta \hat{\Pi}_A - \sin \theta \hat{\Pi}_B \simeq 1.05 \times 10^{-2}$. As a diagnostic, the unmixed pure-basis limits do not show this reversal: pure J_A gives 878 and 126 keV for the 6743 and 6750 states, respectively, while pure J_B gives 1554 and 222 keV. The no-mixing ratios are therefore below unity, in qualitative agreement with the model hierarchy; the opposite baseline mixed-current ratio is caused by the interference pattern above. A flip of the relative J_B radiative sign would restore the model-like hierarchy, but this sign flip is not supported by the tensor-current definition used in the two-point mixing analysis. We therefore keep the vector entries as a baseline convention, not as final physical predictions.

V. CONCLUSION

We have calculated the leading hard-photon QCD sum-rule baselines for $B_{c1} \rightarrow B_c \gamma$ and $B_{c1} \rightarrow B_c^* \gamma$ transitions. The calculation uses physical axial-current residues from the two-point B_c -mixing sum rules and a self-contained vector-current sum rule for $f_{B_c^*}$. The resulting widths show a strong channel hierarchy: $B_{c1}(6743) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$ is very small, $B_{c1}(6750) \rightarrow B_c \gamma$ is at the few-keV level. The vector final-state calculation is internally normalized, but its physical hierarchy remains under sign-convention audit.

The dimension-four gluon-condensate sector has been reduced algebraically, audited, and included through the all-positive denominator sector. The contact/derivative rows do not have ordinary two-channel double-pole support in the physical double-Borel projection, so they are not added to the sum rule. The present calculation therefore gives a transparent QCDSR prediction for $B_c \gamma$ and a documented baseline for $B_c^* \gamma$. Finalizing the vector channel requires an independent rederivation of the tensor-current trace and physical-state assignment.

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